Official Pickle-Ball Rules and History (1965)

I. History

Pickle-Ball was created during the summer of 1965 on Bainbridge Island outside of Seattle, Washington [cite: 3, 70]. The game was invented by US Congressman Joel Pritchard, William Bell, and Barney McCallum [cite: 5, 71]. The original purpose was to provide a sport for the entire family [cite: 4]. Originally, people played in backyards on hard surfaces and driveways [cite: 6]. The game was born out of improvisation when the founders couldn't find a badminton shuttlecock; they used a whiffle ball, lowered the net, and made plywood paddles [cite: 72, 73].

Regarding the name, Joan Pritchard stated it reminded her of the 'Pickle Boat' in crew where oarsmen were chosen from the leftovers of other boats [cite: 74]. While a popular story suggests it was named after the family dog, 'Pickles,' the dog was actually acquired in 1967 and named after the sport [cite: 75, 76, 80].

II. Equipment & Court Dimensions

Pickleball is a racquet sport combining elements of badminton, tennis, and table tennis [cite: 82]. The court size is 20' x 44' for both singles and doubles [cite: 11, 83]. The net is approximately 36" on the sides and 34" in the center, which is two inches lower than a tennis net [cite: 11, 84]. Players use an official Pickle-Ball paddle and a polymer wiffle ball (approximately the size of a baseball) [cite: 9, 85].

III. Rules of Play

The Serve

The serve must be hit with an underhanded motion (paddle below the waist) with one foot behind the back line [cite: 13, 94]. It must be served diagonally across the net and clear the non-volley area [cite: 14, 94]. Only one service attempt is allowed, except in the case of a 'let' serve where the ball hits the net and lands in the correct area [cite: 15].

Double Bounce Rule

Each team must play their first shot off the bounce [cite: 26]. The receiving team must let the serve bounce, and the serving team must let the return of serve bounce before playing it [cite: 27, 99]. After these two bounces, the ball can be volleyed or played off the bounce [cite: 28].

Non-Volley Zone (The Kitchen)

The non-volley zone (or 'kitchen') consists of the first seven feet from the net [cite: 95]. Volleying (hitting the ball in the air without a bounce) is a fault if done while standing in this area or on the line [cite: 37, 38, 95]. A player may only enter this zone if a bounced ball brings them in [cite: 23, 96].

Scoring

Points are scored only by the serving team [cite: 41, 95]. The game is played to 11 points, and a team must win by two [cite: 42, 98].

IV. Singles and Doubles Play

In Doubles:
* The player in the right-hand court always starts the serve [cite: 18, 47].
* At the start of a game, the first team is allowed only one fault before turning the serve over [cite: 16, 101].
* Subsequently, both members of a team serve before the ball is turned over (2 faults) [cite: 17, 102].
* Players switch courts only after scoring a point [cite: 52].

In Singles:
* Each side gets only one fault before a side out [cite: 104].
* Serve from the right court when the score is even (0, 2, 4...) and the left court when odd (1, 3, 5...) [cite: 58, 105].

V. Strategy

Key strategies include lobbing, overhead slamming, and fast volley exchanges at the net [cite: 60]. The team that reaches the front court in a net volley position first is in the best position to win [cite: 61]. The receiving team should hit a deep return and move forward to the net side-by-side [cite: 64]. Shot placement, steadiness, patience, and tactics are more important than brute power [cite: 67].